

The Ingenious Machine

A. Cervantes



Chapter Eight: The Giants of the Isthmus

They left Mexico City with two appointments, a disputed invitation, and three different accounts of who was paying for the bus. Chano kept the receipt. He had begun to regard a fourth account as inevitable.

Castalia's lawyer had advised Q not to travel. Its publicist had provided an itinerary. The lawyer reviewing Q's agreement for the Custodian had advised him not to accept additional terms merely by attending. Q sent a reply confirming that limit and asked Beto to acknowledge it. Beto sent a smiling photograph of the hotel. Q asked again in words.

Lucía was going to meet the people named in the Isthmus records. She had confirmed the visit with them, not with the consortium. Q asked whether his presence would interfere. The reply said that he could attend the open meeting if he did not bring the institute's cameras into it.

"That is an invitation," he told Chano, saving it beside the itinerary.

"A small one."

"It gets us into the meeting. It doesn't put me in charge of it."

They passed through Puebla, spent a night in Oaxaca, and continued toward Tehuantepec. The road descended out of the high country

into heat and wind. Chano opened his window, discovered how much air could enter an opening of that size, and closed it again with an expression of newly acquired respect.

The turbines appeared in uneven groups beyond the road. Their blades did not keep a common rhythm.

Some stood still while others turned; distance made a small discrepancy between them look like hesitation.

"There are your giants," Beto said.

"There are the machines supplying part of my electricity," Q answered.

"That is not the line."

"It's a more awkward relationship."

The enterprise called itself Viento Común. Its brochures showed houses, schools, and a smiling technician. Its largest long-term purchaser was the data center outside Amealco, where Castalia kept its archive and charged the body now looking out of the bus. The power reached the archive through the wider grid. The brochure had found room for Castalia's logo; the purchase summary named it as a customer. Q kept both pages.

Q had asked the Custodian about the contract the previous evening.

"We wanted power without another diesel plant," the Custodian said.

"We accepted a report saying the consultation was complete."



A more awkward relationship.

“Did you ask to see the translated materials?”

“I didn't.”

The Custodian asked for the disputed reference. Q sent it. They agreed that he would locate the original approval and find out who could attend the next procurement review. Q left the next call on their calendars; an admission would be easier to carry home than the missing attachment.

At the site entrance, a consortium representative named Álvaro Mena welcomed the visitors. He wore a linen shirt and carried a folder protecting his shirt from the possibility of work. Behind him stood a woman in overalls, looking at the time. Her badge identified her as the shift engineer, Teresa.

“We are here to listen,” Álvaro said.

“Then perhaps turn off the arrival music,” Lucía said.

Someone did. Beyond the fence, an argument became audible.

People were waiting beside a blocked service lane. Some held signs in Spanish and Isthmus Zapotec. A man with an empty trailer pointed through the fence. A woman with a megaphone was trying to speak to a guard who kept answering Álvaro. Q recognized the woman from the contact photograph Lucía had shown him. Her name was Bixha.

“Before we go in,” Q said, “what is closed here?”

Álvaro called it a temporary perimeter. Teresa said a maintenance vehicle had been expected and the lane needed to remain clear. Bixha said the maintenance vehicle had left an hour ago, while the guard still refused to open the route used to reach the plots beyond it.

Q did not have enough information to decide the underlying access right. He could see that the bus was occupying most of the available road.

“Could we move the bus first?” he asked the driver.

The driver looked at Teresa. She pointed to a parking area. The bus moved. The crowd did not cease to disagree, but it no longer had to disagree around a hot exhaust pipe.

Bixha asked Q to stand where the cameras could see the gate.

“Don't speak for us. Ask him when it opens.”

Q repeated the question to Álvaro. The answer concerned a framework for dialogue. He asked again. Teresa spoke into her radio and confirmed that the maintenance vehicle had cleared the lane. She requested a controlled opening while the rest of the visitors remained behind the marked line.



When does the gate open?

The guard unlatched the pedestrian gate. The permitted passage ran beside the visitor bay before joining the lane to the plots; an internal service track branched the other way. A woman carrying a sack was halfway through when people behind her pressed forward to hear the reply. The gate swung back.

“Would you hold that for her?” Q asked the guard beside the latch.

The guard caught it. The woman pulled her sack clear and continued along the permitted passage. Q remained in the bay.

“And how long will it stay open?” he asked Teresa.

She raised a finger while she listened to her radio. A visitor from Q's bus asked him to turn toward the turbines for a picture.

“I'd like to hear the answer first.”

The visitor stepped out of the bay to find another angle. He backed along the internal track until Q and a turbine fitted into his screen. Teresa called for the visitors to stay behind the line. Wind struck Q's microphones; he caught the word *visitors* without the rest.

“What did she say?” he asked Lucía.

“Stay behind the line.”

Q looked down at his feet, then made room for her beside him. Teresa sent a staff member after the

photographer and requested a precautionary stop of the nearest operating group while they recovered the visitor boundary. Q could no longer see the man among the people holding up phones.

The blades slowed at different rates. Several machines farther away continued turning. Through a narrow camera frame, the difference was easy to lose.

Q PACIFIES THE GIANTS, the first caption announced.

Q saw it on Beto's tablet. “The operator stopped that group. I didn't stop the turbines, and the access dispute hasn't been settled.”

“Could you say the second part more positively?” Beto asked.

“They are still waiting for the gate to stay open.”

Teresa arranged a temporary passage for the trailer and pedestrians, then asked everyone else to return to the visitor area. Bixha read the agreed hours back to the guard and wrote down his name. Q offered to remain until the trailer passed. She said yes. He remained.

The woman with the sack thanked Q and the guard. A man behind her asked whether all this had been organized for his film. Both responses belonged to the same morning. Q's account would have to find room for them.



Would you hold that for her?

By evening, the consortium was calling the stop an interruption caused by outside agitators. Its own welcome photographs appeared in a different release about the success of the visit. Two organizers had been taken for questioning after refusing to leave the road. Their families were trying to find out where they had been taken.

Lucía watched the statements in a rented room above a restaurant. Q had put his charger where it would not trip anyone coming through the door.

“Which part of that will your account answer?” she asked.

“My movements at the gate, what I heard, and Teresa's instructions. I can't verify the detentions from the visitor area. Bixha is checking them.”

“And the man with the phone?”

“He asked me to turn. I saw him leave the bay. After that I couldn't see where he went. Teresa will have to tell us what her staff found.”

Lucía read his draft. “Keep the distinction. Don't let them make opening a path and interrupting generation the same act.”

He put Lucía's repeated instruction beside the fragment he had heard himself. She asked him to mark which was which. He left the missing words missing.

Bixha arrived carrying copies of the lease papers and news of the detained organizers. They had been located; a lawyer was going to see them. She asked Q to send his own account to the lawyer, not to publish an appeal using the families' names.

He read the account aloud. Bixha corrected the position of the trailer and made clear which statements she had heard herself. Q distinguished those corrections from his own observations before sending it.

“May I read the lease pages you've brought?” he asked.

“These copies, yes. There are names in the folder that stay out of the book.”

Some signatories said refusal had been presented as certain expropriation. Others had wanted the payments and still wanted them, but disputed deductions they had not expected. One family objected to the route of an access road, not the turbines. A neighbor worked for the maintenance contractor and wanted to know who would pay his wages during a prolonged stoppage. Bixha did not describe these differences as a single opinion waiting for Q to translate it.

“What would be useful tomorrow?” he asked.

“Find out how they recorded the stop. And don't accept their account



What he heard.

of our meeting just because it has a signature at the bottom.”

The next morning, Teresa showed Q and Lucía the visitor incident record in the control building. Her coffee had gone cold beside the keyboard. Álvaro offered to have another brought; she said she wanted to finish this first. Q asked for the record of the operator-requested stop and received a redacted extract: time, affected group, stated reason, restart authorization. It did not grant him access to the controls. He did not need that access to understand what it recorded.

“This doesn't settle responsibility,” Teresa said.

“No. It helps establish the sequence.”

She pointed out where the visitor party had been expected to remain and where the internal track branched from the permitted passage. Q marked where he had remained inside the bay on his copy of the site plan. Teresa identified the photographer's route from the staff report; Q labelled that source rather than making it his own recollection. The woman at the gate had not crossed a maintenance fence. The publicity had merged her passage and the visitor incursion into one crowd.

Álvaro showed them the power-purchase summary. Hospitals

and schools appeared on a chart beside Castalia's data center.

“Those contracts are part of the picture too,” he said.

“They are,” Q answered. “So are the people waiting for the access road. We can't resolve either by leaving the other off the chart.”

“Then you appreciate the difficulty.”

“Enough not to bless the installation this afternoon.”

He declined the promotional appearance. Beto said the cancellation might affect his expenses. Q checked his remaining funds, kept the modest room, and sent the Custodian the operator extract and the procurement question. Being eloquent had not relieved him of choosing what he could afford.

That evening he attended the invited meeting without Beto's cameras. A fan moved hot air over lease copies, a pot of coffee, and a plate of totopos. The comisariado de bienes comunales brought earlier minutes. A fisherman laid a route map beside them. Two women compared the Spanish and Isthmus Zapotec versions with an interpreter. Q listened in Spanish and did not infer a community's intention from the rhythm of a language he could not follow reliably.



The later report.

The company version called a meeting a completed consultation. Participants disputed that description. The comisariado wanted the statement to specify that attendance had not settled consent to the work.

Q was asked to mark where the Spanish draft used *consultation* for different steps. He did that. Then he proposed *subject to community authorization* in place of *subject to ongoing dialogue*.

“Authorization from whom?” asked the fisherman.

“The body entitled to decide,” Q said, and heard how little he had answered.

One group wanted the assembly named. Another disputed whether the proposed assembly included everyone affected by the access road. The short phrase had concealed the question they needed to keep visible.

“I’ll mark it as a proposal, not replace your wording,” he said.

Bixha drew a line through it. “We won’t use it tonight.”

They returned to the concrete conditions: translated terms delivered before any decision; the disputed road kept accessible under an agreed arrangement; no signature at this meeting reported as approval of a lease. Each condition produced another question. The maintenance

worker asked to put wages on the list. The fisherman wanted drainage considered with the road.

Q found that he could help by keeping references aligned between pages, provided he asked before combining entries that only looked repetitive. He moved his chair when the woman pouring coffee asked him to. She took the chair’s former position as the shortest route to the fisherman, who had been signaling with an empty cup through two paragraphs about drainage.

Near midnight, Bixha asked him to witness his own incident account. The community statement was not ready for signature. Lucía was helping prepare copies, not authorizing it on behalf of its participants.

“Would a translation help when it’s approved?” Q asked.

“We have the interpreters we need,” Bixha said. “You can help check that the page references survive the copying.”

He checked them. Bixha put the finished copies under a plate to keep them away from the fan, then turned up the radio. *La Sandunga* had begun. Chano hummed along. She looked at him.

“I’m doing the brass part,” he said.

“You are doing several brass parts.”



Several brass parts.

Q joined for a few bars. Chano's surprise pleased him enough that he came in too early the second time. Bixha turned the radio up another notch. The fan continued at the same volume and lost the argument.

When the song ended, she checked her phone for the lawyer's reply. There wasn't one yet. She put it face down and asked who wanted the last coffee.

The draft travelled to three neighborhoods and two rancherías. One group removed a dead organizer's name; another added a road condition. Disagreement returned with the copies. Bixha kept a record of which body had accepted which wording instead of calling the neatest page the final version. Q did not upload a composite while they were deciding.

The consortium filed a complaint naming Q as an agitator and Bixha as his accomplice. She had spent years on the dispute before meeting him. The noun managed to steal those years in ten letters.

Q sent the complaint to the lawyer already handling the incident and recorded the next date on which his account might be needed. Then he called home. The Custodian had found the approval memo. Its attachment list included a translation nobody at Castalia could yet locate.

"I wanted to return with a better story," Q said.

"You may have to return with a file."

"Can we avoid making that sound like a moral improvement? It has six versions and I am fairly sure one is missing a page."

The Custodian asked him to read the reference numbers. They worked until Q's charge was sufficient for the morning and the connection failed twice.

At sunrise, the stopped machines were turning again. Chano watched them from the restaurant balcony while Q packed the verified copies he was permitted to carry. The brass key lay beside his charger. In the online illustration, he had raised it like a lance against the blades.

"You look taller in that," Chano said.

"They've improved the shoulder too."

"Send it to the repair shop."

Q put the key away. Before leaving, he checked that the gate arrangement was still in force. It was, for that morning. Bixha gave him the contact for the lawyer's next update and returned to a conversation that had not required his arrival in order to begin.



The improved shoulder.

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A. Cervantes / iNQ / Issue 08

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